

MANDAR DEODHAR

"Dharavi should look like a modern town, no gentrification and ghettoisation, with access to amenities for all"

are funded by the SPV (special purpose vehicle). The developers in SRA (Slum Rehabilitation Authority) projects are always private agencies, but, for the first time, the government is now a partner in the SPV.

On the controversy over the allocation of 541 acres outside Dharavi for rehousing: The objective is proper housing for all. The government has said that those eligible inside Dharavi will be resettled there, and those ineligible outside it. But for that, you need land. The SPV tried in different places. We secured land at the Kurla dairy land and the Jamasp salt pans, but we needed more. The revenue department and agencies concerned who hold the land are taking a call. There is a misunderstanding (among locals) that we are shifting the slums there. We are not doing that, there'll be proper layouts with buildings.

On the 40 per cent compulsory TDR (transferable development rights) for other developers: There are three forms of TDR—roads, municipal TDR for various reservations, and slums. The government feels that slum TDR should get priority and, within it, Dharavi should get priority. It's only up to 40 per cent, developers can buy other TDR too.

On charges that a big section of people will have to exit Dharavi: There is nothing like a perfect project. This is much better than other SRA projects, where people are excluded. We are giving everyone who is eligible a house. We are also putting all the commercial structures within Dharavi, and not shifting them out. ■

all eligible slum-dwellers and industries and commercial establishments will be rehabilitated inside Dharavi. He claims that so far door-to-door surveys have been completed for around 90 per cent of the structures and that the people have also supported it.

FEARS FOR THE FUTURE

The biggest fear among Dharavikars is that the project is being treated as a real estate scheme rather than a resettlement project. Kamalanagar businessman and local Karunanidhi Kannan claims the redevelopment is a "land grab in disguise" and charges that some houses have been numbered by survey teams without consent from residents. He fears that much of Dharavi's population, which derived direct or indirect employment from local units, is likely to be deemed 'ineligible' and pushed out of the area, destroying their livelihoods and the vibrant local micro-economy. "Some people will get houses, but what about jobs? Should they sit outside the houses and beg?" Kannan asks. But others call for a change. "See the conditions we live in, what do you think we need?" asks Swanandi Swami of Latur Galli. Her neighbour, Mahananda Sawale, 63, who stays with her family of nine in a 10x10 ft room, is more blunt. She described her life as "living in the gutters" and wishes for the coming generations to do better.

The Dharavi project will clearly bring as much disruption as goodwill. Gautam Chatterjee, a retired IAS officer and former head of the DRP and Maharashtra Real Estate Regulatory Authority, warns that "while we call it a rehabilitation project, it should not turn out to be a displacement project". For now, Swami holds on to hope: of a flat, a better life and a future where he no longer has to sleep under the bed. For Adani, the question is whether one of the richest men in Asia can truly reimagine the poorest square miles in Mumbai. And whether his colossal wager will be remembered as a transformation—or a miscalculation. ■